

Validity, Reliability & Trustworthiness

How you show your findings can be trusted — the quality criteria

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Quality criteria are the standards by which the rigour of research is judged. In quantitative work these are validity (are you measuring what you claim?) and reliability (would the measurement repeat consistently?). In qualitative work, Lincoln and Guba's parallel criterion is trustworthiness, comprising credibility, transferability, dependability and confirmability. Every methodology chapter must address the relevant criteria explicitly (Lincoln and Guba, 1985).

QUANTITATIVE CRITERIA

Internal validity: the effect is real, not an artefact. External validity: findings generalise beyond the sample. Construct validity: the measure captures the concept. Reliability: consistency on repetition (e.g. Cronbach's alpha for scales).

QUALITATIVE CRITERIA (TRUSTWORTHINESS)

Credibility: findings ring true (member checks, triangulation). Transferability: rich description lets readers judge applicability. Dependability: a consistent, auditable process. Confirmability: findings grounded in data, not researcher bias.

Triangulation — the all-purpose credibility booster. Using multiple data sources, methods, investigators or theories to corroborate findings strengthens both validity and credibility. If two independent routes point the same way, the finding is harder to dismiss. Name your triangulation strategy explicitly.

Concern	Quantitative term	Qualitative term
Truth of findings	Internal validity	Credibility
Applicability	External validity	Transferability
Consistency	Reliability	Dependability
Neutrality	Objectivity	Confirmability

DESIGN IT IN

Rigour is planned, not patched on. Build member checks, pilot tests and audit trails into the method from the start.

KEEP THE TRAIL

An audit trail — raw data, coding decisions, memos — lets an examiner trace how you reached your conclusions. Keep everything.

ADDRESS, DON'T CLAIM

Don't just assert 'this study is valid'. Show the specific steps you took for each criterion that applies to your design.

Common pitfalls. (1) Applying quantitative validity language to a qualitative study. (2) Asserting rigour with no evidence of how it was achieved. (3) No pilot test of instruments. (4) Ignoring researcher bias in qualitative analysis. (5) A missing validity/reliability section — a frequent flag.

REFERENCES

Lincoln, Y.S. and Guba, E.G. (1985) *Naturalistic Inquiry*. Beverly Hills: SAGE. · Saunders, M., Lewis, P. and Thornhill, A. (2019) *Research Methods for Business Students*. 8th edn. Harlow: Pearson. · Yin, R.K. (2018) *Case Study Research and Applications*. 6th edn. Thousand Oaks: SAGE.